



Rise. Register. Grow.

In business, leaders often talk about a "VUCA" world — one defined by Volatility, Uncertainty, Complexity, and Ambiguity (Bennett & Lemoine, 2014). Prices shift overnight, regulations change, and the road to formalising a small food business can feel impossible to predict. That is exactly the world our traders are operating in. So in this VUCA world, we are here to help you VUKA ;-)

Journey 4: Customers Should Trust Your Food

This is **Journey 04** of the VUKA curriculum: every journey a food trader needs, from checking whether you're ready to grow, right through to scaling into a bigger business, in one consistent, scenario-driven format.

Each lesson takes 3–7 minutes: a real scenario, a quick explanation, one practical tip, a quick challenge, and a badge.

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Journey 4: Customers Should Trust Your Food

"Would you eat in your own kitchen right now?"

Trust is the real product you're selling. The food is just how customers experience it. This journey shows you how to earn that trust, and prove it when someone asks.

Would You Eat In Your Own Kitchen?

"Be honest. Would you eat in your own kitchen right now?"

A health inspector checks a few basic things: is your prep area clean and easy to wipe down? Are your fridges cold enough? Do you keep raw meat away from cooked food? Is there somewhere for staff to wash their hands? These are the exact things Regulation R638 (R638 of 2018) checks before giving you a Food Permit.

 **QUICK TIP** Do your own mini-inspection once a week using this same list, before an inspector ever does it for you.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Walk through your kitchen right now and check these four things. Complete this and earn:  "Kitchen Ready" badge

Five Things Customers Notice First

"Would a stranger trust your food from how it's packaged, before they even taste it?"

Customers judge food safety before they even eat, from your packaging, your labels, and how you handle food in front of them. If you sell pre-packaged food (not made-to-order), the law (R146) says your label needs a few key things: what the product is, the ingredients, how much is in the pack, and who made it. If it contains a common allergen, that has to be clearly stated too.

 **QUICK TIP** If you ever write something like "low sugar" or "high protein" on a label, the law (R146) requires a full nutrition table too, so only make that claim if you're ready to back it up.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Look at your current packaging. Does it have all five things a customer needs to see? Complete this and earn:  "Trust Builder" badge

Keep Food Fresh For Longer

"How long can that chicken really sit out before it's a problem?"

Temperature is the single biggest food safety risk. Cold food needs to stay cold, hot food needs to stay hot, and the zone in between is where bacteria grows fastest. This is one of the main things inspectors check under R638 (R638 of 2018).

 **QUICK TIP** Get a cheap fridge thermometer. Guessing the temperature is how most food businesses fail an inspection.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Check your fridge temperature right now, and write it down. Complete this and earn:  "Cold Chain Champion" badge

Simple Cleaning Habits That Keep You Legal

"If an inspector walked in right now, could your staff explain how they were trained?"

The law (R638 of 2018) says the person in charge of your kitchen must have proper food safety training, and so must anyone helping you handle food. You also need to keep some proof of this, even just a simple written record of who was trained and when.



 **QUICK TIP** *Keep training proof as photos or notes on your phone. A simple record beats no record, every time.*

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Ask each person working with you: "When did you last get food safety training?"

Complete this and earn:  **"Clean Team" badge**

Growing? New Rules Might Kick In

"What happens the moment you start canning your famous chilli sauce to sell in stores?"

Some products carry extra risk once you scale. Canned, smoked, or vacuum-packed foods are checked by a separate regulator (the NRCS), not just your municipality. If you want to supply a retailer like Pick n Pay or Checkers, they'll often ask for their own proof of food safety, on top of your permit.

 **QUICK TIP** *Before you invest in new equipment for a new product type, check whether it changes your legal category. It can save you from an expensive mistake.*

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** List any new products you're planning, and circle any that are canned, smoked, or vacuum-packed.

Complete this and earn:  **"Ready to Scale" badge**

Sources for Fact-Checking: Legislation & Regulation

Every legal fact in Journeys 3, 4, and 10 is drawn from current South African legislation and regulator guidance:

- Regulations Governing General Hygiene Requirements for Food Premises (R638 of 2018), under the Foodstuffs, Cosmetics and Disinfectants Act 54 of 1972 — enforced by municipal Environmental Health Departments.
- Regulations Relating to the Labelling and Advertising of Foodstuffs (R146), under the Foodstuffs, Cosmetics and Disinfectants Act 54 of 1972 — Department of Health.
- Businesses Act 71 of 1991 — gov.za.
- Companies Act 71 of 2008 and Companies and Intellectual Property Commission (CIPC) — company registration, business structure conversion, and trade mark registration — cipc.co.za.
- National Regulator for Compulsory Specifications (NRCS), Food and Associated Industries division — canned, smoked, and vacuum-packed products — nrcs.org.za.
- South African Revenue Service (SARS), Small Businesses – Taxpayers, Tax Compliance Status system, and Budget 2026 Frequently Asked Questions (VAT and Turnover Tax threshold changes effective 1 April 2026) — sars.gov.za.
- Unemployment Insurance Act 63 of 2001 and Unemployment Insurance Contributions Act 4 of 2002 — Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- Compensation for Occupational Injuries and Diseases Act 130 of 1993 (COIDA) — Compensation Fund, Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- Basic Conditions of Employment Act 75 of 1997 — Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- National Environmental Management: Waste Act 59 of 2008 and Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) Regulations (Government Notice R.1184, 2020) — Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment — dffe.gov.za.
- Broad-Based Black Economic Empowerment Act 53 of 2003, and the Codes of Good Practice on B-BBEE (Exempted Micro-Enterprise thresholds) — dtic.gov.za.
- Protection of Personal Information Act 4 of 2013 (POPIA) — Information Regulator South Africa — info regulator.org.za.
- Consumer Protection Act 68 of 2008 — online and distance sales provisions — gov.za.



- African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) — South African implementation guidance — dtic.gov.za.

Note: municipal fees, thresholds, and application processes vary by area and are periodically revised by government and regulators. Verify current requirements directly with the relevant municipality or regulator before publishing final figures in the app.

Sources & Further Reading: Business Practice, Marketing & Financial Literacy

Branding and digital marketing facts in Journeys 6 and 7 draw on the following:

- Cloudfusion (2025). 7 Essential Reasons Why Branding Is Important for Business. Cloudfusion.co.za.
- Dandu, R. (2015). What Is Branding and Why Is It Important for Your Business? Brandingmag.
- Mercer, S. (2026). What to Post When You Have Nothing to Post: 10 Content Ideas for Summerville Businesses. What's Up Summerville.
- Why food photography is important for your food business. candyfoxstudio.com.
- Yolisa Motha (2021). A Guide to Branding a Small Business. iKhokha.

Statistics on South African small business communication, time management, professionalism, networking, record-keeping, and banking (Journeys 1, 2, 8, and 9) are drawn from national small business research. Verify current figures against original sources before publishing final numbers in the app.

Growth-readiness, lending-risk, funding, and stock-management facts in Journeys 1, 2, 5, and 9 draw on the following:

- National Debt Advisors (2021). Stay away from unregistered money-lenders. nationaldebtadvisors.co.za.
- Startup Mag (2025). Scaling Signals: Ten Signs Your Small Business Is Ready to Grow. startupmag.co.za; Lula (2025). 5 Signs Your Business is Ready for Growth Capital. lula.co.za.
- RegInsights (2024). Small Business Funding. regenesys.net/reginsights.
- Graduates24 (n.d.). NYDA Grant Programme Small Business Funding in South Africa. graduates24.com.
- Okhantu (2025). SEDFA Funding 2026: Requirements, Amounts & How to Apply. okhantu.co.za.
- Ready Accounting (2026). Inventory management tips for cost savings and efficiency. readyaccounting.co.za.
- Xtraspace (2024). Small Business Inventory Management in SA: 10 Top Tips. xtraspace.co.za.

Sources & Further Reading: The VUCA Concept

The mission statement on the cover page draws on the following:

- Bennett, N., & Lemoine, G. J. (2014). What VUCA Really Means for You. Harvard Business Review, 92(1/2), 27.

